No one had been less forthcoming to our team psychologist than me, but over ninety minutes or so I opened up to him for the first time in that bar in Adelaide. I was honest about my battles with myself. Everyone talked about my mental strength and thought I had cracked the most difficult aspect of the game, but I had big doubts each time I went out to bat.

It was strange. For someone who consciously struggled to articulate deeper thoughts and personal motivations, the words flowed like a torrent. I admitted to walking out thinking, 'I don't want to be here today. I can't be bothered with the effort of scoring runs.' That inner voice would tell me: 'We're on a green seamer. It's not flat, it's not your day. They're going to get you out.'

I had issues with public speaking and was astonished to find in the book that someone as accomplished as Obama, a new president at the time whose speeches were characterized by their fluency and emotional impact, had admitted to underlying unease. 'Is it normal?' I asked Bawds. 'It can't be, surely?'

It was.

We talked about the private trials, during the night before and on the morning of a game. I confessed to an ache, deep in the gut. A poached egg on toast for breakfast felt like it had the consistency of cardboard. I relied on my natural stubbornness to get through the first half hour of an innings, when I would settle down, but the anxiety never truly left me.

When I was out cheaply, I had too much time to think, because my chance to atone might take two or three days to arrive. I maintained the façade of strength and imperturbability, but the game regularly beat me up. My life as a batsman was black and white: if I scored runs, I was a success; if I didn't, I was a failure.

I just offloaded. Bawds explained I had become consumed by what I couldn't do, rather than dwelling on what I could do, what I had done. He sought to reconnect me, remind me of the virtues that had made me a good player. Everyone suffers from fear and self-doubt. My values, my love of family and trust in friends, were still strong. My priority was to reset and rebuild my relationship with myself.

Bawds asked what I wanted to achieve. That involved coming to terms with the facts of an athlete's life. The nerves would always be there. Why waste energy trying to fight them? It sounded so simple and basic. I confessed that I longed to be free, to push aside the negative thoughts and